



Deciding bout: India's Jaismine Lamboria (blue) battles Poland's Julia Szeremeta (red) in the World Boxing Championships final on her way to the title. GETTY IMAGES

allow herself more downtime. Descended from one of India's greatest boxers and with multiple national champions in her immediate family, she has carved out her own legacy with a World Championships gold. She won the title the hard way, too — in an Olympic weight division, beating Olympic silver medallist Julia Szeremeta in a final most observers felt she dominated.

Jaismine insists that, World champion or not, she isn't competing to see who the best boxer in her family is. "*Race thodi hai!* (It's not a race). Everyone in my family has the same dream as I, which is to make India proud. *Jab national anthem bajta hai woh best feeling hai* (It's the best feeling when the national anthem plays). That's the moment I want to create again and again," she says.

She is already thinking about how to recreate that feeling. "Right now, I'm feeling good. Our team's

performance was also really good (India finished second overall in the women's tournament with two gold medals, including hers). I'm feeling full of confidence but *aage aur bhi karna hai* (I have to do more in the future)," she says.

Her family might wish she spent more time with them, but they understand. They've seen it before.

Last year, three days after returning to Bhiwani from the Paris Olympics, Jaismine had already packed her bags and left for the Army Sports Institute (ASI) boxing centre in Pune.

For many athletes, the Olympics would be a career highlight. For Jaismine, it was a source of dissatisfaction. Her journey there had been remarkable. She wasn't even supposed to go — her compatriot Parveen Hooda had already qualified in the 57kg category. But after she was handed a 22-month suspension for whereabouts failure, Jaismine seized her chance. The 57kg division wasn't natural for her — she had competed in 60kg before — but she took the risk and, against all odds, secured a quota at the World qualifiers.

At the Olympics, though, she was

beaten soundly in her very first round. Although she finished far from the medals, Jaismine sees the Games as crucial for her development.

Preparing for the future

"There are two ways to look at how I did at the Olympics. It was disappointing to lose, but at least I got the experience of competing at such a big tournament. I also got the chance to be next to elite athletes. I could watch them, their behaviour, how they trained and how they motivated themselves. After I lost my bout, I would go to the stadium and watch all the fights. I saw how the score was going and how the judges were scoring. I observed all this so I could learn and apply it to myself when I got the chance again in the future," she says.

The moment the Olympics ended, Jaismine says she began putting into training what she had learned. "I knew I could have done well myself and that experience made me feel I couldn't just sit down and relax after my own tournament ended. For a lot of people, the Olympics was the end of their goals, *par mera journey wahi se shuru hua hai* (but for me, the Olympics is where my journey started)," she says.

Aggressive switch

Jaismine, a subedar in the Central Military Police, says she spent seven months in a row training at ASI. "After the Olympics, I knew I had time to prepare for my next competition. My coaches — (Mohammad) Ehteshamuddin sir and Chhote Lal sir (former coach of Mary Kom) — did a lot of technical work with me. All the results I got are thanks to the work we did. At the World Championships, I was able to implement what they taught me," she says.

"There were a lot of changes I had to make. I had to work on my strength. I also made small changes to my technique. For example, I was boxing a lot on the back foot. I started training to box more on the front foot. I added more cross punches to my game."

She also felt she had to change her temperament. According to Dr. D